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Motivation Handoff Guide

Use this guide when you need to describe **goals, non-goals, risks, assumptions, trade-offs, and open governance questions**.

This guide is about **why** the system exists and what strategic forces shape it.

KNOWLEDGE AREA

This guide helps with **goals, risks, assumptions, and trade-offs**. Technically, it covers **strategic intent, risk, and assumption management**.

Guide family map

Where this guide sits in the full Blueprint Handoff Atlas family.

ROOT & CROSS-CUTTING

Handoff Atlas

Blueprint Bundle

Metamodel Vocabulary

Migrations

DESIGN

Architecture

Concepts

Domain

Dynamics

Infrastructure

Interactions

Models

Quality

Rules

Story

GOVERNANCE

Capability

Decisions

Motivation

Organization

Roadmap

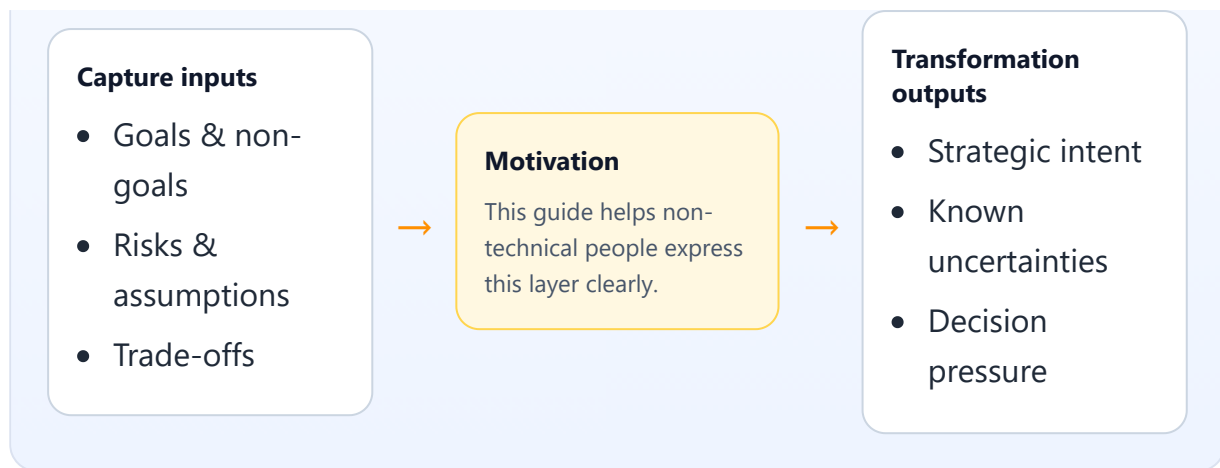
Leverage

Test Cases

Value Stream

Capture → focus → transformation

What to gather first, what this layer focuses on, and what a modeler or AI agent can produce from it.



Main entities in this guide

- **Goal** — an outcome the system or organization is trying to achieve.
- **Non Goal** — something intentionally out of scope, even if it sounds nearby.
- **Risk** — a meaningful threat to the goal or delivery outcome.
- **Assumption** — something believed true and relied on, but not guaranteed.
- **Trade Off** — a conscious balance between competing goods or constraints.
- **Inquiry** — an open question that still needs an answer.
 - Often confused with: a **Decision**. Motivation captures intent, uncertainty, and tension; decisions capture chosen direction.

What belongs here

- goals and desired outcomes
- non-goals and boundaries
- risks and threats
- assumptions that may prove wrong
- trade-offs between competing concerns
- unresolved strategic questions

What does not belong here

- detailed process steps
- final decisions without their surrounding motivation
- raw metrics without a strategic purpose

Core things to capture

- what is being aimed for
- what is intentionally out of scope

- what could go wrong
- what is being assumed
- what tension exists between important concerns

Core relationships to capture

- goal -> quality measure or capability supported
- risk -> goal threatened
- assumption -> consequence if false
- trade-off -> concerns being balanced
- inquiry -> decision or clarification needed

Modus operandi

Use motivation to make implicit reasoning visible:

1. state the goals clearly
2. name what is out of scope
3. identify risks and assumptions
4. capture tensions and trade-offs
5. record unresolved questions that block good decisions

Prompt set

- what are we trying to achieve?
- what are we explicitly not trying to do?
- what could threaten the goal?
- what are we assuming is true?
- what tensions do we accept consciously?

Free-text intake template

- **Goal / non-goal / risk / assumption / trade-off / inquiry:**
- **Statement:**
- **Why it matters:**
- **What it affects:**
- **Consequence if ignored or false:**

Worked example

- Goal: customers can submit return requests without contacting support

- Risk: inconsistent return decisions create fairness and cost concerns
- Assumption: policy rules capture return eligibility well enough to decide quickly
- Trade-off: faster self-service returns vs tighter manual control

Layer-specific handoff guidance

For motivation, the handoff should make **strategic pressure visible**.

The receiver should be able to distinguish:

- goals from non-goals
- risks from assumptions
- trade-offs from decisions

If the handoff mixes these categories together, later design and governance work will blur.

How this becomes YAML

A technical modeler or AI agent can transform this into motivation entries that later connect to decisions, quality measures, and capabilities.

Common mistakes

- writing vague goals with no clear intent
- hiding assumptions inside decision text
- omitting non-goals
- listing risks without saying what they threaten